



Melodic journey: As he drives through the streets of Pakistan, Adnan shares his love for Indian music.

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today)," remarked a porter, guiding the Diary to the immigration centre. As he loaded the luggage into the car, he offered a tip: "*Local khana zaroor khayein...* (Do try the local food)," enthusiastically recommending must-have delicacies.

Driver Waqas, a die-hard cricket fan, nodded in agreement. The 40-minute drive to Lahore's Allama Iqbal International Airport was filled with his animated discussions about Virat Kohli, whom he admired greatly. At the airport, a massive Champions Trophy poster featuring all eight captains stood prominently. Nearby, a group of young fans clicked selfies, capturing the moment.

The flight to Karachi was smooth, and two hours later, a large sign outside the airport greeted the Diary — 'Welcome to Pakistan'.

On a Sunday afternoon in Lahore, at the Niazi bus station, a group of youngsters sat huddled in a corner, eyes glued to a smartphone. A roar erupted as Babar Azam struck a boundary against India in the Champions Trophy in Dubai. Cricket had once again united strangers in a shared moment of passion.

"*Yehi cricket hain, sabko ek saath kar deta hain* (Cricket unites everyone)," said Amjad from Dera Ismail Khan. "All of us are strangers, but on match days against India, everyone becomes a friend." He regretted that India wasn't playing at Gaddafi Stadium, calling it a missed

once-in-a-lifetime experience.

Nearby, travel agency customers and drivers had gathered around TV screens. Initially confident, the mood soured as Pakistan lost quick wickets. "*Yaar, yeh koi run tha!* (There was never a run there!)," an elderly man exclaimed in frustration as Imam-ul-Haq was run out.

Saud Shakeel and Mohammad Rizwan briefly revived hopes, but as their wickets fell, spectators quietly dispersed and boarded their buses.

"*Aap ki team to jeet gayi* (Your team won)," remarked the hotel reception staff in Islamabad. The hotel had planned a match screening, but with Pakistan's semifinal hopes diminishing, the area lay nearly empty.

"It would have been wonderful if the team had won [against India], but people will still turn up in Pindi to show their support," said a hotel staffer. With a smile, he added, "I would love to watch Kohli in action someday." Posters of Kohli and Rohit Sharma adorned city streets, a testament to their immense popularity. On the drive from Lahore to Rawalpindi, driver Adnan was delighted to learn the Diary was from India. "India se ho? Aap ko kuch sunata hoon (You're from India? Let me play you something)," he said, grinning as he played Kumar Sanu classics.

"I'm a big fan of Kumar Sanu. I've loved his songs since childhood," he said, playing "*Sajna Sajna*" and "*Kitna Pyar Tumhe Karte Hain*."

"One day, I'd love to meet him," Adnan added, mentioning his love for Noor Jahan and Atif Aslam. "But when it comes to Hindi music, Sanu best hain..." he said with a grin. "*Idhar toh Hindi gaane kaafi chalte hain* (Here, Hindi songs are quite popular). I love listening to old songs..."

Shayan Acharya

Muted buzz

Meanwhile, the ICC Champions Trophy's hybrid model, in which Dubai hosts only India's matches while the rest of the tournament takes place in Pakistan, has resulted in little buzz about the event in the



Dampened enthusiasm: There was no shortage of support for Team India inside the Dubai International Cricket Stadium. However, the same couldn't be said for the city as a whole, with the overall buzz surrounding the tournament remaining fairly muted. PTI

UAE's biggest city.

Tournament signage is largely restricted to the area surrounding Sports City, as one enters the Dubai International Cricket Stadium.

The only real sign of the tournament taking place was through the Diary's interactions with cab drivers, who were eager to strike up a conversation about cricket upon spotting a group of reporters with accreditation cards around their necks.

Most of the cabbies we encountered over the past week were from Pakistan, often reflecting the prevailing sentiment regarding their team's dismal state.

On the ride back from the stadium to our hotel, another driver from Pakistan offered us a lift from inside the stadium and welcomed us by congratulating us on India's win. He then provided a point-by-point breakdown of the game's key moments.

It was all good until he decided to throw a curveball at the end of our trip, quoting four times the price of a standard fare — perhaps hoping that a group of Indian scribes would be charitable following the Men in Blue's victory. Though we managed to settle for the usual fare, one can't blame him for trying to hustle us on a day when his team surrendered without a fight.

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